What Does a Good Day Look Like?

A worksheet for writing down what your wife wants to keep, in her words and apart from your guesses.

“She'd want things to stay the same” is your guess. “My own kitchen, and bridge on Thursdays” is her answer, and her answer is the one to keep.

Fill this in after you've talked, not while you're talking, and over more than one conversation if that's how it goes. Write what she said, the way she said it. Where she hasn't said, write “haven't asked yet” and leave it.

A good day, as she tells it

Ask her to walk you through a day she'd call a good one, from the morning on. Write it in the order she tells it.

FOR EXAMPLE “Coffee on the porch before anyone's up. Then the crossword, and nobody talks to me until it's done.”

The routines she wants to keep

The daily ones, the weekly ones, and the ones that come round once a year. Only the ones she named herself.

FOR EXAMPLE Bridge on Thursdays. Church at nine, not eleven. Thanksgiving at our house, with her stuffing.

Her own words about what matters most

The sentences you'd want to remember exactly. Use quotation marks only where you're sure of the wording.

FOR EXAMPLE “I've made my own breakfast for fifty years and I intend to go on making it.”

What she wasn't sure about, or didn't want to talk about

Write these the way she left them. They're for another day, and she picks the day.

FOR EXAMPLE Asked who she'd want around if she ever needed a hand. She said, “Let me think about that one.”

What I assumed that she didn't say

Go back over the page. Anything that's your conclusion and not her words moves down here, so it isn't mistaken for hers.

FOR EXAMPLE I'd written “wants everything to stay as it is.” She never said that. She said she loves the garden and her Thursdays.

When we talked, who wrote this down, and whether she has read it

What this shows you

Three things: what she said she wants to keep, what she left open, and how much of the picture was yours and not hers. It doesn't show what should happen next, because nothing has to. This page isn't a plan or a profile, and nothing on it adds up to a score. What the kids hope for, and where the family agrees or doesn't, is a separate conversation for another day.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what she wants to keep, in her words, with your own guesses set to one side. The care interview adds the rest of the picture: it goes through your wife's situation area by area, so her wishes sit beside a full account of how she lives now, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The good-day question is one The Conversation Project's starter guide asks. Asking someone to walk through a day, and sorting routines into daily, weekly and occasional, follows the Administration for Community Living's person-centered thinking toolkit. Keeping a person's own words is how the Institute for Healthcare Improvement's toolkit encourages care teams to record what matters.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
2. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
3. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults